Scouting America

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Executive Summary

The Boy Scouts of America has seen a major drop in membership over the years, going from around 5 million members in the 1970s to fewer than 1 million in 2024. This steady decline raises concerns about the organization's long-term future and whether it still connects with younger generations today. Because of this, the goal of our research was to better understand why membership is decreasing and to come up with realistic ways to help it grow again.

To do this, we focused on a few key questions. Specifically, we looked at what factors prevents individuals from joining or continuing participations in BSA, to what extent individuals are aware of BSA programs and how to participate, what the current level of engagement is, and how social perceptions, peer influence, and public reputation affect willingness to participate in BSA.

We collected our data through an online survey that was shared with students at The University of Texas at Dallas, along with friends, family, and their networks. In total, we received about 25 responses, giving us a solid range of perspectives from our target group.

From the results, a few clear patterns stood out. Most people are familiar with the Boy Scouts of America, but that awareness doesn't necessarily lead to participation. There's also a noticeable gap between people who know about it and those who are interested in joining. The biggest reasons for not participating were preference for other sports or activities, followed by the time commitment restraint and organization reputation. This shows that practical issues like time and cost, along with overall perception, play a big role in why people stay away.

Overall, the research suggests that while the Boy Scouts of America is still well known, it needs to evolve to better fit today's lifestyles and expectations. Making the program more flexible, more affordable, and more appealing through modern marketing could be key steps in bringing memberships back up.

Research Problem Description

The main problem this research focuses on is the steady drop in membership in the Boy Scouts of America and trying to understand why it's happening. Even though the organization is still widely recognized, fewer people are choosing to join or stay involved. This suggests there may be a disconnect between what the program offers and what today's younger generation is looking for. Factors like time, cost, awareness, and overall perception could all be playing a role. By better understanding these reasons, we can figure out what's holding people back and what changes could help make the program more appealing and relevant again.

Research Questions

- What is the current level of engagement for BSA among the target population? (Participation status)
- To what extent are individuals aware of BSA programs and how to participate? (Awareness)
- How do individuals evaluate the value and modern relevance of BSA programs? (Perception)
- What factors prevent individuals from joining or continuing to participate in BSA programs? (Barrier of engagement)
- What are the implications for BSA or similar organizations? (What to do)

Methodology of Data Collection

This study used a Qualtrics survey to collect data from the current perspective of Scouting America. The target population for this study was students at the University of Texas at Dallas, friends, family, and people within their network. The method that was used was a convenience sampling method focusing on participants that were most likely to participate in the survey. Each member of the team sent out an electronic survey through text, email or posting on a forum. The survey consisted mainly of yes or no, multiple choice, and Likert Scale questions. We ensured that the questions were easy to understand, did not have over complicated answer choices, and were unbiased. Responses were also all anonymous, which helps get honest responses from the participants. The survey was sent out at the end of March and has recieved feedback from participants throughout the next following month.

Findings

Finding 1: Declining Participation Is Not an Awareness Problem

Survey results indicate that awareness of **Scouting America** remains high among respondents. A total of 90% reported being aware of the organization, and approximately 64% indicated past or household participation in scouting programs.

Because the sample included a large proportion of respondents outside the typical youth participation age range, current participation levels were not used as a primary indicator of engagement. However, the high levels of awareness and prior exposure suggest that declining participation is not driven by a lack of familiarity with the organization.

Instead, these findings indicate that the primary challenge lies in converting awareness and past exposure into sustained engagement, pointing to underlying issues related to program structure, perception, or competing priorities.

Finding 2: Strong Initial Appeal, but Inconsistent Experience Limits Retention

The data suggests that scouting continues to attract participants through its core value proposition. Among respondents with prior experience, 50% identified outdoor and adventure-based activities as the primary reason for joining.

However, participation appears to decline over time. Most respondents reported involvement during elementary school years, with decreasing participation through middle and high school. Additionally, advancement data shows that many participants do not progress beyond early ranks.

Qualitative responses provide further context, highlighting inconsistencies in program experience across different troops. Respondents noted variations in leadership quality, instances of favoritism, and differences in overall troop culture. These inconsistencies suggest that while initial interest in scouting is strong, uneven program delivery may limit long-term engagement and retention.

Finding 3: Participation Is Being Prioritized Behind Other Activities

The findings indicate that scouting is competing with other extracurricular activities for time and attention. A total of 56% of respondents reported a preference for other activities, and 44% identified time commitment as a barrier to participation.

This suggests that scouting is not necessarily lacking interest but is instead being deprioritized in favor of other structured commitments, particularly sports and school-related activities.

At the same time, respondents expressed strong interest in outdoor skill development (64%) and shorter, more flexible program formats (56%). This indicates that while demand for scouting-related experiences remains, the current structure may not align with how individuals and families choose to allocate their time.

Finding 4: Brand Perception Is Mixed and Impacted by Reputation Concerns

Survey results reveal that brand perception is a significant factor influencing participation. Over half of respondents (52%) cited concerns related to organizational reputation, and 40% identified safety concerns as a barrier.

Open-ended responses further highlight concerns related to organizational changes, particularly the inclusion of girls in the program. Multiple respondents expressed dissatisfaction with this change, indicating that it may be contributing to divisions in perception among certain groups.

Additionally, qualitative feedback pointed to issues such as inconsistent leadership, favoritism, and negative peer experiences, which may further influence overall perceptions of the organization.

Taken together, these findings suggest that reputation challenges, combined with internal changes and inconsistent program experiences, are impacting how scouting is perceived and may influence participation decisions.

Conclusion

In conclusion, from the research we have done and the data we have collected we can see that the decline in Scouting American membership is not caused by the low brand recognition or lack of awareness. In fact, the real reason behind the decline in membership is the Brand perception, inconsistent experiences, and competition from other activities. Although most of the people are still interested in the values of Scouting America, having only interest is not enough for the people to stay in the program. Overall, the research shows that the focus should not be on brand awareness, rather it should be on how to keep people engaged for a longer time.

Limitations

Limitation 1: Small Sample Size

This study is based on approximately 25 survey responses, which limits the ability to generalize findings to the broader population. The results should be interpreted as directional insights rather than definitive conclusions.

Limitation 2: Age Distribution of Respondents

A significant portion of respondents were adults outside the primary age range for scouting participation. This limits the ability to draw conclusions about current participation rates and may skew findings toward retrospective perceptions rather than current experiences.

Recommendations

Based on the findings from both the quantitative survey data and the qualitative open-ended responses, several clear opportunities emerge for Scouting America to improve participation and long-term retention. While awareness of the organizations remains high, the primary barriers to engagement stem from program structure, inconsistent experiences, and brand perception.

Recommendation 1: Introduce Flexible, Adventure-based Participation Options

One of the most significant barriers identified in this study is the time commitment required for participation, as well as competition from other extracurricular activities. Survey results indicate that 56% of respondents prefer other activities, while 44% cite time commitment as a major constraint. At the same time, there remains strong interest in the core value proposition of scouting, with 64% expressing interest in outdoor skill development. This suggests that the issue is not a lack of interest, rather a misalignment between program structure and participant lifestyles.

To address this, Scouting America should introduce a more flexible participation model. This would allow participants to engage in scouting activities on a pay-per-event basis without requiring long-term membership commitments. Additionally, implementing alternative participation tracks for older students, such as monthly or seasonal involvement options, would better accommodate the schedules of middle and high school students. By reducing rigidity and offering modular engagement opportunities, Scouting America can better compete with sports and school-related commitments while still delivering the core experiences that initially attract participants. This approach would help convert interest into participation and improve retention among older age groups.

Recommendation 2: Standardize Troop Experience and Strengthen Accountability Measures

The findings indicate that while initial interest in scouting remains strong, inconsistent program experiences significantly limit long-term engagement. Although 50% of respondents reported joining for outdoor and adventure-based experiences, participation declines sharply after early years, particularly as scouts transition into middle and high school. Both the survey data and open-ended responses highlight that variability in leadership quality, troop culture, and overall

experience plays a major role in this decline. Qualitative responses specifically identified issues such as bullying, favoritism in leadership selection, and unequal access to advancement opportunities. These experiences contribute to a perception of scouting as inconsistent and, in some cases, unfair. The findings also reinforce that inconsistent leadership and troop culture are key drivers of disengagement.

To address this issue, Scouting America should implement standardized policies and accountability systems across all troops. This includes mandatory leader certification and annual training to ensure a consistent baseline level of leadership quality. Furthermore, a zero-tolerance anti-bullying policy, combined with an anonymous feedback system for scouts and parents, would allow issues to be identified and addressed more effectively. Establishing clear and standardized criteria for leadership roles and advancement opportunities would also help reduce perceptions of favoritism and improve fairness. By creating a more consistent and equitable experience across all troops, Scouting America can improve retention, enhance participant satisfaction and ensure that all scouts have equal opportunities to benefit from the program.

Recommendation 3: Rebuild Trust Through Clear Positioning and Modern Marketing

Although awareness of Scouting America remains high, with 90% of respondents indicating familiarity with the organization, this awareness does not translate into participation. Instead, the brand perception presents a significant barrier due to the history of the organization. The survey findings show that 52% of respondents cite concerns related to organizational reputation, with 40% specifically mentioning safety concerns. The open-ended responses further highlight concerns related to organizational direction, cultural positioning, and program focus. These findings indicate that Scouting America must actively work to rebuild trust and modernize its brand image. A key step in this process is the development of a targeted marketing campaign focused on transparency, safety, and positive outcomes. This campaign should emphasize the organization’s reforms, highlight real success stories from scouts, and clearly communicate the value of participation in terms of personal development and leadership skills.

Additionally, Scouting America should shift its positioning away from a traditional, rank-focused organization toward a more experience-driven model centered on fun, skill-building, and personal growth. Leveraging social media platforms can showcase authentic scouting experience and help improve relevance among younger audiences and their families by addressing perception challenges and aligning its messaging with modern expectations, Scouting America

can improve its public image, increase trust among parents, and ultimately convert high awareness into participation.

Together, these recommendations focus on three critical areas: flexibility, consistency, and perception. By making participation more adaptable. Ensuring a higher quality and more equitable, and rebuilding trust through modernized positioning. Scouting America can better align with the needs and expectations of today’s participants and families. Implementing these changes will be essential for reversing declining membership trends and sustaining long-term growth.